via excavations in and around the rocks of the large cavern. But certainly it made sense to engrave a message within a place ritually visited: what appears an idiosyncratic location may not have been so then. That said, considering that the area for people to gather in by the edict is limited, the audience at any point in time was unlikely to have been a large one.

Maski folk who came to the outcrop could hardly have failed to ask local officials about the emperor. The name ‘Ashoka’, inscribed at Maski, would through constant use have become familiar. The declamatory use of a first-person voice revealed that he was a Buddhist, a religion which would have been perceived to have a new and powerful backer. People thousands of kilometres away from their emperor in Pataliputra would at the very least have been curious about what he was saying to them in this dramatic and unexpected way, by inserting himself into their landscape. For a community with connections in the large subcontinental world, the imperial presence in this form may even have been considered an honour specially bestowed to the area. The assurance of an egalitarian moral universe may have struck an emotional chord: the most humble cultivator at Maski was being told that he was not inconsequential and could exalt himself merely by following in the king’s footsteps.

These are some possibilities. It is also possible that the notion of a mingling of gods and humans sounded alien to the populace. The Buddhist faith was not a part of the local sacred landscape, nor did anything in the king’s message show awareness of Maski’s ancient religious practices. The message on the rock had been parachuted into their midst, and his expectation that they move in a direction simply because he had personally chosen it could have seemed foreign and unconvincing. During Ashoka’s lifetime and subsequently, Maski reveals no change in its faith. There are several bruisings on the rocks here—circles, fish symbols, and much else—but nothing remotely resembling Buddhist symbols. No Buddhist stupas were ever constructed here during or after the third century BCE, such as